THE ANNOTATED MURDER

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The Blackwood Ridge Mysteries, Book 1

AUDIOBOOK NARRATION MANUSCRIPT

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Title page and narrator notes are not for recording.

NARRATOR NOTES - DO NOT RECORD

Record the chapter numbers and chapter titles. Do not record this notes page. The manuscript contains no retailer-specific review request or promotional back matter.

OCTOBER 2026 REVISION - READ FIRST

Four small continuity fixes were made after the July copy. In this PDF the changed paragraphs are highlighted in yellow. Re-record the highlighted passages in the order they appear here; every other word is identical to the July copy. (The two moved Chapter Two paragraphs beginning "On the word threads" and "His notes, though" may be spliced from your existing takes if you prefer - their words did not change, only their position.)

1. **Chapter Two** - paragraph beginning "The shop opened at ten": the long drive home is now the long walk home. Callie walks to the auction in Chapter One and owns no car in this book.
2. **Chapter Two** - paragraph beginning "She sold almost nothing": was "She sold nothing," which clashed with the birthday gift she wraps in the same paragraph.
3. **Chapter Two** - the exchange beginning "No." Mae smiled: restructured so Mae's hands go still on the word "threads" instead of two paragraphs later. Three highlighted paragraphs are read in the new order shown.
4. **Chapter Seven ("The Reckoning")** - paragraph beginning "Not the bell. The knock": Callie now puts on her coat before answering the door, so her taking it off later in the scene tracks.

Names and terms

Callie Thorne: CAL-ee THORN
Mae Hartwell: MAY HART-well
Augustus "Gus" Ralston: uh-GUS-tus; RALL-stun
Wendell Pike: WEN-dull PIKE
Eli Townsend: EE-lie TOWN-zend
Jacob Wren: JAY-cub REN
bergamot: BUR-guh-mot
Ridgeway: RIJ-way
The Foxed Page: "foxed" rhymes with "boxed"

Latin

Use a lightly Anglicized scholarly pronunciation throughout; consistency is more important than strict historical reconstruction.

Linea vera abest tres gradus ab inscripta: LIN-ee-ah VAIR-ah AH-best trays GRAH-doos ab in-SKRIP-tah

Minister moriturus. Equus, via nota. Non casus.: MIN-is-ter mor-ih-TOO-rus. EH-kwoos,

WEE-ah NO-tah. Nohn KAH-soos.

S.R. iussit: Ess ar YOO-sit

iudex emptus: YOO-deks EMP-toos

Performance guidance

Callie: restrained and precise; emotion is controlled, not absent.
Mae: unhurried warmth and moral weight; avoid a caricatured regional accent.
Sheriff Cross: clipped and procedural, with respect emerging gradually.
Gus: a warm public baritone whose charm drains in stages.
Eli: anxious and fragmented, but never comic or childish.

CHAPTER ONE: THE AUCTION

The Auction

Two years after there was no one left to keep quiet for, Callie still stepped over the floorboard behind the archive table — automatically, without looking, a habit older than memory. Her mother had slept in the room above the shop, and the courtesy of not waking Eleanor had outlasted Eleanor by two years and showed no sign of stopping. She still stepped over it.

The back room of The Foxed Page smelled of leather bindings and cold stone and, faintly, of bergamot. It always smelled of bergamot. Callie had brewed the same tea every morning since she was nineteen, had kept the same tin on the same shelf, had poured it into the same chipped mug with the hairline crack running down its handle — Eleanor's mug, Eleanor's tea, Eleanor's tin. She told herself it was habit. Habits were clean. Habits didn't require an explanation she couldn't give.

The mug sat on the oak table now, cooling, beside the brass magnifying glass she'd been using on a shipment of estate acquisitions. The glass had a satisfying weight to it, balanced exactly for a woman's hand — her mother had chosen it for exactly that reason, had placed it in Callie's palm at nine years old and said, *The truth is always there, Callie. Most people just don't look closely enough.* Callie turned it now between her ink-stained fingers, letting the lamplight run along the beveled edge, then set it down on its felt rest. Her fingers left a faint print on the brass. She didn't wipe it away.

On the shelf above the table, the shop's oldest binding stood open where she'd left it, and Eleanor's handwriting moved down the margin in its easy loops — the first hand Callie had ever learned to read, a hand she would have known in the dark. She didn't look at it. She didn't need to.

The reading glasses hung on their chain against her collarbone. She hadn't needed them an hour ago. Now, with the light going amber and the rain starting up against the front windows, she hooked them over her ears by reflex and looked at the clock.

Six-fifteen. The auction started at seven.

Callie rinsed the mug — she always rinsed it, never left it, never let the tea ring dry to brown — and pulled on her coat. The rain was the light, steady kind that would keep up all night, tapping the glass like someone patient at a door. She locked the back room, locked the shop, and stepped out under the awning. The square's gas-lamp lights were already on, halos in the wet, and the brick walkways gleamed the color of old tea.

She crossed the square on the diagonal, head down against the fine mist. The town hall rose on her left, stone and serious, the archives under it in their climate-controlled dark — her second workshop, the place she spent more hours than anyone in Blackwood Ridge knew. She went to auctions less for the buying than for the being-there: the company of people who cared about paper and provenance and the slow weight of things that had outlived the hands that made them. She went, if she were honest in the way she refused to be, to be among people who understood what she did. And tonight she went, in part, because Wendell Pike would be there, and Pike was the closest thing she had to a colleague, and she had never once used the word *friend* to describe him.

The Ridgeway Auction House stood on the far edge of town, a converted tobacco warehouse with its high ceilings and exposed brick preserved as character rather than repaired as damage. Tonight the track lighting picked out rows of folding chairs, a raised podium, and a long display table where the evening's lots waited under glass — first editions, a handful of maps, a slim volume of nineteenth-century surveying records that was the reason Callie had marked her calendar three weeks ago. She'd bid on quieter things than this, and lost.

She paid her entry, took a program, and let the warmth of the room close over her. Sawdust and furniture polish and, underneath, the mustiness that lived in any building where old paper was stored. A comfortable smell. A cataloguable one.

The old-money crowd had turned out in force. Callie recognized the shapes of families more than the faces — the set of a jaw, the way a woman held her shoulders, the cut of a coat that signaled money older than the person wearing it. She moved along the edge of the room, nodding to the people she knew, accepting a cup of coffee she knew she wouldn't drink.

Then she heard the laugh.

Augustus Ralston held court in the center of the room the way he always did — not by raising his voice but by lowering it, so that people leaned in. He had a baritone that carried warmth the way a good radiator carried heat, and he was telling some story about the auction house's previous life, his hands moving in easy, expansive gestures, his silver hair catching the light. Three people stood in his orbit, and every one of them was smiling.

"Callie." He found her without scanning, the way he always did — as if he kept a register of where the useful people were standing. "There she is. I was hoping you'd come." He crossed the last few feet and took her hand in both of his, a grip that was firm and brief and exactly calibrated. "How's the shop? Mae was saying you had a leak in the storeroom last month. You tell me the minute that turns into anything structural. I know a man."

"The shop's fine, Mr. Ralston. Dried out within the day."

"Gus." He smiled, releasing her hand. "How many years have we known each other?"

The smile was perfect. It was always perfect. Callie had watched him deploy it across the counter of her shop, across the polished table at the Historical Society he funded, across every town function for as long as she'd been attending them. It was the smile of a man who'd never needed to think about his face.

"You know the last time Wendell came to one of these," Gus said — and the name landed between them with a casualness that wasn't casual at all. "What was it, the Henley estate sale? He spent forty minutes schooling the auctioneer on a binding date. Forty minutes." He shook his head, still smiling. "He's in the back tonight, though. Been a hermit lately — good to see him out." He adjusted his cuff link — twice, the same spot. "You two still trading notes on his little project?"

"From time to time."

"Wonderful. Wonderful." Gus beamed. "That's what I love about this town. People keeping the past alive." He squeezed her shoulder — lightly, briefly, the touch of a patron — and turned back to his circle, already starting a new anecdote over his shoulder, drawing the warmth with him.

Callie stood very still for a moment after he'd gone. Something about the way he'd said *little project*. She filed it the way she filed everything — precisely, without deciding what it meant yet — and moved on.

Eli Townsend was restacking programs near the entrance, and when he saw her his whole body gave a small involuntary flinch. "Oh — Ms. Thorne. Hi. Sorry, I didn't — they moved the display table, I was just—" He was already talking with his hands, plucking at the string of his hoodie. "Can I get you anything? There's coffee, but you probably have coffee, you always — I mean, not that I track what you — sorry."

"I'm fine, Eli. Thank you."

He nodded too fast, too many times, and his eyes slid past her toward the back of the room where they stayed for a beat too long before snapping back. "Right. Great. Lot Fourteen's the surveying records — I pulled them forward for you, figured you'd want a look. That's Dr. Pike's, he was the one who—" He stopped. Swallowed. "Anyway. You'd have read the program." He laughed, high and thin, at nothing. "I'll just—"

He retreated into the stacks before she could answer. Callie watched him go. She had seen Eli nervous before — he was nervous the way other people were calm, as a default setting — but tonight there was a tightness under it, a current running through the fidgeting that she couldn't name. She registered it the way she registered a foxed page or a misaligned binding: something off. She connected nothing to it. There was nothing yet to connect.

She found Pike in the back corner, exactly where Gus had said, hovering over a table of lots with a paper cup in his hands and his reading glasses pushed up into his unruly white hair. He looked up when her shadow crossed his papers, and his face did the thing it always did — the small brightening of pleasure, the quick caution that tightened his jaw, and then a looking-over he turned away from — before settling into academic affability.

"Callie. Good, good. You came." He cleaned his glasses on his cuff, a tic so constant the fabric was worn thin at the spot. "I was hoping you'd — well, not hoping, that's strong, but. You know." He gestured vaguely at the room. "Lot Fourteen. The surveying records. I've been wanting to — there are some annotations I haven't shown you yet, and I think — well, we'd need the physical volume, the scans lose the pressure of the hand, and pressure matters, Callie, it always matters—"

"You're drinking bergamot," she said, because she'd only just noticed.

Pike looked down at the cup as if he'd forgotten he was holding it. "Oh. Yes. Well." He gave a small, sheepish shrug. "It's the only thing that settles them when I've been at the archives all day — they go when I'm onto something, you know that."

She did understand. For a second she was aware of the brass glass on its felt rest across town, and of the tea she had rinsed from Eleanor's mug that morning — the same ritual in a different hand. Pike was the only other person she'd ever met who drank it, who treated it as ritual, not drink. It had been one of the first things they'd had in common, years ago, before their collaboration had a name.

"Will you sit with me?" she asked. "During the auction."

"I — yes. Yes, I'd like that." He smiled, and for a moment the academic armor dropped and he was just an old man who was glad not to be sitting alone. "We'll talk after. About the annotations. There's a great deal to — well. After."

The auctioneer climbed the podium. The first lots went up — a first-edition Hurston, a Civil War-era map of the valley — and the room settled into the particular hush of people preparing to spend money with dignity. The Hurston went for more than it was worth to a woman in the third row whose paddle rose once and never wavered. The map drew a brief, polite war between two men who clearly had history; it ended in a tight smile and a shake of the head.

Callie watched the lots turn over with the professional half-interest of someone waiting for her own number. Fourteen. The surveying records. She had come for those the way a collector comes for a missing piece — not to own it but to be in the room when it surfaced, to see whose paddle rose and what that told her. Pike would have thoughts on the binding. She wanted to hear them.

She let her shoulders ease. The rain had picked up against the high windows, a low steady hiss, and the track lighting threw a warm, even gold over everything. Beside her, Pike turned his paper cup slowly in his hands, and the bergamot rose faintly into the heated air between them.

Between the third lot and the fourth, Callie saw Gus rise from his seat near the front and move toward the back of the hall. She tracked him without meaning to — the archivist's eye noting movement the way it noted a turned page — and watched the silver hair disappear down the corridor that led to the restrooms and the back offices. A word with someone, she thought. A phone call. The auctioneer announced Lot Four, and she turned back, and the moment slid away into the rhythm of the gavel.

During the bidding for Lot Four, Pike touched Callie's sleeve, murmured that his tea had gone cold, and carried the paper cup toward the refreshment station beside the back offices. She watched him disappear down the same corridor Gus had taken, then turned back when the bidding jumped.

She had just begun to relax — genuinely, for the first time all week — when the side door banged open.

One of the auction-house staff stood in the frame, pale, and the words came out in a rush that didn't quite parse until the second time through. Back office. A man. On the floor. Not breathing.

Callie was on her feet before she'd decided to stand. She was at the back office door before the auctioneer had finished calling for calm. And then she was in the room, and the room was very small, and it was very quiet, and Pike was on the floor beside his overturned chair with his reading glasses three feet from his hand and a paper cup tipped on its side beside him, a dark curl of tea spreading slowly across the concrete.

His tea. His bergamot. Cold now — she didn't touch it, but she could see the surface stillness of it, the way a cold liquid holds its meniscus differently from a warm one. She knew the exact temperature of a cup of bergamot tea gone cold, because she had knelt beside one once before, two years ago, on this kind of floor, in this kind of silence. Her mother's heart, the doctor had said — quiet, expected, a thing that happened to women who lived alone with their work. There had been nothing to find, and nothing anyone could have done.

The auctioneer was saying something about a doctor. Someone was on the phone. The room had not turned into chaos — the old-money crowd was too well-trained for chaos — but it had gone

brittle, every face turned toward the back, every conversation stopped mid-syllable. Callie knelt because her knees decided to, not her, and she did not reach for Pike because she knew what she would find, and she did not cry out. The catalogue was already running, even now, even now. Reading glasses. Upturned cup. The angle of the right hand. The stillness.

Heart attack, someone said behind her, in the tone of someone who needed it to be true.

She stood. The room recatalogued itself around her: the warm track lighting, which was the same; the hiss of rain, which was the same; the bergamot, which was — which was exactly the same as the bergamot in the tin on her shelf and in the cup she'd left cooling on the oak table in the back room where her mother had died. And underneath the sameness, something else. Something that had no shape yet, only a weight, settling low and cold in the center of her chest the way sediment settles in still water.

Sheriff Cross arrived twenty minutes later, hat in his hand before he was fully through the door. He was a tall man going soft at the middle, with a permanent tan line at his forehead and the pressed crease of someone who ironed his own uniform. He took statements in a level tone that made everyone he spoke to sound like a suspect, including, briefly, the deceased.

"Ms. Thorne." He found her standing where she'd been standing for twenty minutes, which was as close to the back office as the staff had let anyone remain. "You were sitting with him."

"For the first three lots."

"He say anything about his health? Heart trouble? Medication?"

"No."

"Stress?" Cross leaned against the doorframe, arms folded. "He been under any kind of pressure lately?"

Callie thought of the annotations Pike had wanted to show her. *There's a great deal to — well. After*. She adjusted her reading glasses on their chain. "No more than usual."

Cross wrote that down, or appeared to. His pen moved. His face did not. "We'll know more once the medical examiner takes a look. Until then, this is a natural death, and I'd appreciate it if people didn't start talking about murder at a book auction." He said it to the room as much as to her, raising his voice for the last half. No one in the room had said the word murder. No one needed to. The word was already in the air, the way the bergamot was.

Eli Townsend was across the room, near the entrance where Callie had first seen him, and he was talking to a deputy with the rapid, overflowing fluency of a man who could not stop himself explaining. Callie watched from a distance. His hands were everywhere — tugging his hoodie string, gesturing, pressing flat against his own thighs as if to hold himself in place. His eyes would not settle on the deputy's face. He looked, to anyone who didn't know him, exactly like a man with something to hide.

Callie did not move to help him. She did not yet know he needed help.

The room emptied slowly, in the manner of people who had been trained to leave functions gracefully even when the function had become a death. Callie realized, standing in the brittle quiet, that she had not seen Gus Ralston since the third lot. He had gone down the back corridor and she had not seen him come back, and she had not seen him leave, and now the room was nearly empty and there was no silver hair among the remaining faces. She thought nothing of

it. There was too much else to think of. The rain swallowed the square beyond the windows, the auction house lights were still up, and somewhere in the back office a paper cup lay on its side with a curl of cold tea spreading across concrete that would never quite come clean.

Callie stood in the quiet for a long time. She did not know yet why she was staying, only that the cold curl of bergamot had lodged somewhere behind her sternum and would not leave. The rain hissed against the high windows; the auctioneer's podium stood empty under the gold light. And Callie Thorne, who had spent two years handling the dead the way she handled documents — with clean hands, at arm's length — stood very still in the middle of a crime scene that hadn't been called one yet, and began, without meaning to, to catalogue.

CHAPTER TWO: THE AFTERMATH

The Aftermath

The tea tasted wrong.

It was the same tin, the same water, the same three-minute steep she had performed every morning for sixteen years, and it tasted of cold concrete and a paper cup tipped on its side. Callie set the mug down on the oak table, beside the brass magnifying glass on its felt rest, and looked at it the way she would have looked at a document that contradicted itself. The tea was fine. The tea was bergamot, as always. The tea was the problem.

She poured it out and brewed another. The second cup tasted the same as the first.

The shop opened at ten, as it had since Eleanor's day. Callie unlocked the front door, turned the sign, stepped over the floorboard without thinking, and stood behind the register, waiting for the day to have a shape. Rain. Still rain. The same patient hiss against the front windows that had been hissing all night, that had hissed through the auction and the statements and the long walk home with the mist on her coat and her hands deep in her pockets and her mind somewhere very far from the square. The square outside was wet and grey and empty.

She sold almost nothing. Two people came in — one for a birthday gift she gift-wrapped without speaking, one to browse the regional history shelf and leave without buying. Both of them looked at her a beat too long on the way out. People were already looking at her differently. She was the woman who had been sitting next to him.

Sheriff Cross came at half past eleven. He removed his hat on the threshold — genuine, that, not performance — and stood inside the door with it pressed against his chest, rain beading on the brim. He had not slept; she could see it in the grain of his eyes and the soft damp crease where he'd been gripping the hat brim for hours.

"Ms. Thorne. Got a few more questions, if you can spare a minute."

"Of course."

He did not sit when she offered. He leaned against the doorframe to the back room, arms folded across his chest, and asked about Pike's routine — where he worked, who he saw, whether he'd seemed himself lately. The questions came in a level, measured tone, each one phrased to sound casual and land like a deposition.

"Did he have any disagreements with anyone? Anything recent?"

Callie thought of the annotations. *There's a great deal to — well. After.* "He was a historian, Sheriff. Academics disagree about everything. It's how they talk to each other."

"Hm." Cross wrote something down. "You know the Townsend boy? Works at the auction house?"

"Eli."

"Witnesses put him in a shouting match with Dr. Pike, the week before. Something about a misfiled document." Cross watched her face while he said it. "Boy's been… hard to pin down on the details."

"Eli's hard to pin down on everything." She met his eyes. "Anxiety isn't guilt, Sheriff."

"Most people who act guilty have a reason." Cross said it mildly, almost kindly, which was worse than if he'd said it sharp. "Medical examiner's still out on cause. But a man his age, no heart history, going down at an auction — I like to know who had a grievance."

He paused there, studying her, and Callie felt him weighing something — not her words, but the shape of what she wasn't saying. He rubbed the back of his neck, a gesture she had seen town officials make when the agenda had outpaced them, and for a moment he looked less like a sheriff than like a man who had sensed the ground getting soft under his boots and could not find the edge of it. Then the moment closed over and he was the sheriff again.

He set his hat back on his head. "You think of anything Dr. Pike was working on that had him rattled, you let me know."

Callie watched him go. She did not tell him about the annotations, or the surveying records Pike had wanted to show her, or the way Pike's hand had been shaking — with excitement, she had thought then, with excitement — when he'd spoken of the pressure of the hand. She held it back the way she held back the breath before a sneeze: instinctively, before she had decided to. And in the holding-back she felt the first small turn of something between them, a hairline crack, the knowledge settling that his methods — baggies, chain-of-custody forms, a man's alibi weighed on a scale — were not built for the kind of evidence that mattered here. He would look at Eli's nervousness and see guilt. He would look at a margin note and see nothing at all.

She was still turning this over when the bell rang and Mae Hartwell came through the door with a thermos and a covered dish and the smell of lavender and rain.

"Callie Thorne. You haven't eaten." It was not a question. Mae set the dish on the counter — soup, still warm, the kind she appeared with at every birth and death and small crisis in a three-block radius — and began to ladle without waiting for permission. "Sit. Eat. The shop can mind itself for ten minutes."

Callie sat. The soup was good. She had not known she was hungry, and the hunger shamed her — the body going on, insistent, when the decent thing would have been to stop.

Mae did not sit. She moved along the shelves, straightening books that did not need straightening, her hands busy with spines the way her hands were always busy — knitting, stirring, arranging. Still hands let the guilt in; Callie had never said this aloud, but she had watched Mae long enough to know it was true. She watched her now, the unhurried shuffle between the stacks, the silver hair catching the reading-lamp light.

"Terrible thing," Mae said, to a shelf. "Terrible, terrible thing. Your Dr. Pike."

"He wasn't my Dr. Pike."

"No." Mae turned a book a quarter-inch. "No, I suppose not. You two were close, though. Working on something together, weren't you? He used to come in here of an afternoon." She glanced over her shoulder, and the glance held a care that was also a question. "He ever talk to you about what he was researching? Some old town matter, I heard."

The question sat between them. Callie heard the softness in it and, underneath the softness, something taut — a line pulled tight and waiting to see how much weight it would bear. Mae was asking carefully. That was new.

"Some land records," Callie said. "Early township surveys. Nothing that would upset anyone."

"No." Mae smiled, and the smile did not quite reach the rest of her face. "No, I'm sure. Just — some old things are better left where the roots have settled, honey. You know how this town is. We've gotten on all these years by not pulling at certain threads." She paused, her hand resting on a spine.

On the word *threads*, her hands stopped moving. It lasted less than a second — a stillness so brief that anyone else would have read it as a pause for thought. But Callie had spent a decade reading pauses, and this was not a pause for thought. This was a woman whose hands had been keeping something at bay and had, for one unguarded instant, failed. Then they were moving again, straightening the same book, and Mae was smiling the same careful smile, and Callie understood that she was watching someone hold something shut with both hands.

"His notes, though. Wendell's. He keep all that at the archives, or did he have copies floating around? Papers somewhere else?"

The question was too specific. Callie looked at Mae's back, at the hand resting too still on the book, and felt it land differently than the others. Not *what was he working on* — Mae had already asked that. This was *where are his papers now*. She filed it the way she filed everything, without deciding what it meant.

"At the archives," Callie said. "As far as I know."

Mae set down the book she was holding. "You promise me you'll eat the rest of that soup."

She left before Callie could answer. The bell rang behind her. The lavender stayed, faint, in the folds of the air.

Callie looked at the door for a long time after Mae had gone. She was thinking about the way Mae had said *certain threads*. She was thinking about the careful way she had asked. She filed it. She did not yet know what she had.

At a quarter to four she locked the shop, told herself she was going upstairs, and walked instead to the town hall.

The Blackwood Ridge Town Archives lived in the basement — stone walls, climate-controlled vaults, rows of filing cabinets, bound records back to the founding. Cold air. The low hum of fluorescent tubes. The particular institutional hush of a room built to keep things safe from time. It was Callie's second home, her other workshop, the place she spent more hours than the council knew; she had a key, and she used the key, and she signed the leather-bound log on the front desk — *C. Thorne, 3:47 p.m., reference* — the way she always did, without thinking, because the log was the law of the place.

Pike's table was in the far corner, by the east vault. She could see, from halfway across the room, that it had not been touched.

His manuscript pages were fanned across the oak in the order of a mind mid-thought — notes here, a photocopied survey there, his annotated working copies stacked at angles. His reading glasses, the spare pair, folded on a book. A cold cup of tea — bergamot, bergamot, of course it was bergamot — at his elbow, half-finished, a faint brown ring already drying at the watermark. Callie stood over the table and did not touch anything for a full minute. She could smell him here. Old tweed and paper and the sweet dust of a man who lived in archives. He had sat in this chair yesterday, or the day before, and he had been alive, and he had been afraid, and he had not told her how much.

She sat down in his chair, and the cuff of her coat still held the ghost of Mae's lavender — the warm world following her into the cold one. She pulled his working copies toward her, and the room narrowed.

It narrowed the way it always narrowed, when Callie read a hand — the rest of the world dropping away until nothing existed but ink and intention. Pike's handwriting was cramped and urgent, slanting harder the more excited he got, the letters crowding each other like people trying to leave a room. She knew this hand. She had read it across her own counter, in good light, with tea between them, and it had been the handwriting of a man delighted by his own find. This was not that hand. This was the handwriting of a man looking over his shoulder.

Confirmed — S.R. signature matches forged survey lines. Margins decode true boundaries. J.W. did not lie. See expanded findings, MS pp. 31-36. The scope — God, Callie, the scope of it.

She read it twice. Then a third time. The pressure of the pen told her what the words did not: he had pressed harder on *scope*. He had gone back and underlined *did not lie*. He had been afraid, and he had been certain, and he had written *God, Callie* as if he were already speaking to her across the table about it, as if there would be an after. And there would not be. She sat with the note and understood, with a small sick drop, that she had read him his whole life the way she read a binding — closely, usefully, never once calling it what it was. She had done the same thing to Eleanor. She was a woman who only ever finished people once they were closed.

S.R. The R she knew — Ralston, the name on the plaques of the old buildings, on the wing of the library, on the checks that funded the Historical Society where Mae served punch at the annual lecture; the name that opened doors and silenced questions. The S she could not yet place. Whatever the initials pointed to, Pike had been afraid of it, and the fear had been growing.

She did not yet know what Pike had found — only that it had the Ralston name in it, and that anything with the Ralston name in it carried the weight of the town's whole story. She had always known, in the abstract, what he was chasing. Sitting in his chair with his cold tea at her elbow, she knew it now in the specific — the weight of it, the human cost of it, the families it would crack open. Mae's questions took on a new shape in her memory.

Callie reached for the manuscript pages he had referenced. Pp. 31–36. Whatever the heart of it was — the part Pike had been saving, the part that would turn the initials into a name and a crime — lived in those pages. He had described them to her only in outline, in the oblique way academics describe things they are not yet ready to share whole. She had not read them. She had meant to. There had been time, and then there hadn't.

The pages were gone.

Not misplaced. Not misfiled. She checked twice, then a third time, running her fingers along every edge. The numbering jumped — 29, 30, then 37, 38. And where 31 through 36 had been, the binding told its own story: a clean tear, even, the fibers pulled straight, done by someone who knew what they were doing and did not want the rest of the manuscript to show the wound.

Six pages. The six pages that mattered.

Callie sat back in Pike's chair. The fluorescent hum filled the silence. The cold tea sat at the dead man's elbow, and the room smelled of cold stone and the faint sour dust of old paper, and the stone walls pressed in the way stone walls press when a building is holding something heavy.

Someone had been here. Someone had known which pages to take — which six, exactly, out of a hundred — and had taken them cleanly, and had not disturbed the rest, because the rest was cover; the rest made it look like nothing was missing unless you knew what to look for. Someone had read the manuscript first. Someone had sat where she was sitting now and understood exactly what Pike had found.

The same someone, almost certainly, who had left that other cup of bergamot to go cold on a concrete floor.

Callie looked at the cold cup. She did not pour it out. She did not move it. She looked at it, and the thing that had sat in her throat since the auction turned over and showed its other face. Something with edges. She was behind. She had arrived second. The work a good man had died over was half-erased, and the eraser was still walking around town shaking hands and funding the Historical Society and touching his cuff link.

She reached for her key — the old instinct to lock up and leave — then stopped. She reached instead for Pike's surviving notes and the photocopied surveys underneath them. The brass glass was on its felt rest back at the shop; she had not thought to bring it. She would not forget again tomorrow.

Pike had started at the beginning. She would start where the pages were missing, and she would read backward, and she would find what he had found — because the margins remembered what the missing pages did not, and the margins were the part no one thought to take, because no one but Callie and Pike and one frightened surveyor a hundred and eighty years dead knew how to read them.

The fluorescent light buzzed. She opened the first of Jacob Wren's annotated surveys and began, at last, to hunt.

CHAPTER THREE: THE TRAIL

The Trail

By ten o'clock on the third morning the word *poison* was in every cup of coffee on the square — not announced but absorbed, molecule by molecule, until no one could say who'd been first to know.

Callie heard it from a customer who did not buy anything, who stood at the counter and spoke about it in the hushed tone people use for deaths that have turned out to be worse than they thought, as though being murdered were an indelicacy Dr. Pike had committed. *They're saying it was poison, Callie. In the tea, some are saying. Or something in the tea. They're saying it's a murder now.* She listened. She gift-wrapped nothing. When the customer left, she stood behind the register for a long minute with her hands flat on the wood and her breathing even, and she did not let herself react.

Poison. Of course it was poison. She had known it from the moment she had seen the still meniscus of that cold cup. A man of sixty-eight does not die of his heart at a book auction with his tea half-finished unless the tea is the point. The medical examiner had caught up to what the bergamot had already told her. It did not change anything. It only made the shape of the thing she was hunting sharper.

Sheriff Cross arrived just after noon, hat in his hand on the threshold again. This time there was no damp crease in the hat brim, no un-slept grain in his eyes. The crease in his uniform was sharper now — the crease of a man who had decided.

"Ms. Thorne." He did not sit. He stood on the other side of her counter the way he might have stood on the other side of an interview table, and his voice had shed the kindly mildness of two days ago. "I'm going to be plain with you, because plain saves time. The medical examiner's findings make this a homicide. That changes everything about this. Including where you stand in it."

"I understand."

"I'm not sure you do." Cross set his hat on the counter, brim up, the way a man sets down a thing he is about to need. "This is a homicide now, Ms. Thorne. Not a research project. I've got a dead historian and a roomful of people who all had somewhere to be that night, and I cannot have an amateur muddying witness statements and poking through evidence because she's curious."

"I haven't poked through any evidence, Sheriff."

"That's not what I hear." He held her gaze. "I hear you were in the archives yesterday afternoon. Signed the log at quarter to four. Now, the archives are public, and you've got a key, and I'm not telling you where you can and can't read. But I am telling you that if anything in that room bears on a homicide, it is evidence, and evidence is my department. Not yours. We clear?"

Callie looked at his hat on the counter. She thought about the six missing pages and the clean tear of the binding and the fact that the man standing in front of her would bag the pages if he had them but could not read a single line of what was written on the ones that remained. "We're clear," she said.

"The Townsend boy." Cross picked up his hat. "I'm going to be straight with you there, too. He had words with the deceased a week back. Witnesses heard it. No alibi for the time of death. And the boy can't sit through a conversation without looking like he's done something. I'm not saying he did it. I'm saying he is, at this moment, the man my evidence is pointing at." He settled the hat on his head. "You have any thoughts on him, you bring them to me. You don't go running your own side investigation. There's a word for people who interfere with a homicide case, and I would rather not use it to a lady who runs a bookshop."

He left. The bell rang behind him. Callie stood very still behind the counter and listened to the rain on the front windows and the quiet of the shop and the low angry pulse in her own throat.

She had heard the rigidity in him. She had heard the warning. What she had not heard was the other thing underneath it — the small unprofessional kindness of telling her, in advance, exactly where his investigation was pointing. She filed it as procedure and missed it entirely.

Eli. The wrong man's face was assembling itself into a case file across town, and Callie could see exactly how it would lock together — the argument, the nerves, the empty alibi, the way the boy's fear would read as guilt to anyone who had not learned to tell the difference. She could not stop it from the counter of a bookshop. She could only stop it from the archives.

She locked the shop at noon. She told herself, again, that she was going upstairs, and she walked, again, to the town hall.

The basement was colder than it had been yesterday, or she noticed it more. The fluorescent tubes hummed their institutional hum. She signed the leather log — *C. Thorne, 12:14 p.m., reference* — set her bag on Pike's table, and drew the foundational survey records toward her: the bound copies of Jacob Wren's original township surveys, 1840 and 1841, the pages brittle at the edges, the iron-gall ink gone the brown of old tea. She had read these surveys a hundred times. She had never read them the way Pike had been reading them.

She set Eleanor's glass on the page.

The room narrowed. Not slowly this time — it dropped away all at once, the fluorescent hum and the cold of the stone walls falling off behind her until there was only the four-inch margin and the marks a frightened man had made in it a hundred and eighty years ago. Wren's hand was small and careful, the letters cramped by the effort of writing in a space not meant for writing, and underneath the care she could feel the haste. He had been working fast. He had been working afraid. She could see it in the slight downhill slant, in the places where the nib had dug too deep, in the three words he had written and then crossed out and written over again, as if his first instinct had been too clear and he had needed to bury it.

He had buried it in Latin. The surveyor's old trick — the language no one in a county magistrate's office would trouble themselves to read. *Linea vera abest tres gradus ab inscripta* — the true line is three degrees from the recorded one. Callie read it once, slowly, the way she read cipher, letting each contraction resolve before she took the next. The abbreviations were Wren's own, a system she had begun to recognize from Pike's notes: *ab inscr.* for *ab inscripta*, the little crossed L for *linea*. She had taught herself the key over weeks, alone at the back-room table, the way she had taught herself every code that mattered — by patience, by cross-reference, by the slow accumulation of one dead man's habits.

And underneath the Latin was the cipher — the private layer, the part meant for no one. A string of letters that were not abbreviations and not words and not, to anyone but the man who had written them and the woman now reading them, anything at all.

She traced them with the glass. She read them as a measurement, because the Latin had been a measurement — some further offset, she assumed, a finer correction. They would not parse. She tried them as bearing-figures; they would not parse. She tried them as a date. Nothing. The cipher sat on the page, mute, and she could feel it watching her the way a locked drawer watches a woman without the key. She had the wrong assumption. She had been reading it as a number because the Latin had been a number, and the cipher was not a number at all.

She sat back. She breathed. She reached for the photocopied survey beside the original — the official record, the one that had been filed, the one that had stood for a hundred and eighty years as the truth of where the Ralston land began and the Hartwell land ended — and she laid it beside the page, and she read the cipher again, not as a measurement now but as a surveyor's witness-mark, the old notation a man left when he had been made to file a thing he knew was false.

And the cipher opened.

Not three degrees. Not a number. A line of attestation, abbreviated to its skeleton and then letter-substituted so that only another surveyor — or a woman who had taught herself a dead surveyor's habits — would read it clean: *I filed this contrariwise, and under constraint, and I set the true line here for the record.* Wren had not made an error. Wren had been made to lie, and he had buried his retraction in the only place the men who made him could not read.

Three degrees.

The recorded survey line ran northwest along the ridge. The true line, the one Wren had hidden in the margin in a dead language and a private cipher, ran three degrees west of it. She did the arithmetic in her mind first, and then, because she did not trust anything she could not see, she did it again on the scrap paper Pike had left. Three degrees, over the length of that boundary, was not three degrees. It was a hundred and forty acres. A hundred and forty acres of ridge and creek bottom and good hardwood forest, lifted off the Hartwell grant and folded, quiet as a letter, into the Ralston holdings.

She sat back. The forged survey line. The stolen land. The fortune built on it, and the family name that still wore that fortune a hundred and eighty years later on every plaque and every wing in town. Wren had hidden the truth in the margin because he could not speak it aloud and could not, apparently, let it die with him. He had written it for exactly this — for the woman with the glass who would come along a century and a half later and look closely enough.

Callie looked at the margin note, and then at the faint pencil underneath it, the layer laid down in a different hand, a modern hand, Pike's hand: *Verified against the filed copy. J.W. filed under duress. God, Callie — it's all of it.* Two voices, a hundred and eighty years apart, both frightened, both compelled, both writing to a woman who had not been born yet for one of them and had failed the other. She felt them in the room with her — the surveyor and the historian — the way she sometimes felt Eleanor in the back room, a presence in the hum of the room. Margin notes as voices.

She did not cry. She pressed her fingertips to the page, very lightly, on the place where Wren's ink met Pike's graphite, and she sat with it for a long moment, and then she turned the page.

There would be more. She knew there would be more, because Pike had been at this for months and had died before he finished, which meant the trail went deeper than a single boundary line. She would read every margin in this volume, and then the next, and she would decode them one by one, and each one would bind her a little tighter to the work and a little tighter to the cost of it. She could feel the cost already — a low tug, like an undertow, pulling her further out.

The bell of the shop rang, eventually, in her memory, and she surfaced, and it was evening, and the basement windows were dark, and she had been there for five hours without noticing.

She let herself back into the shop. She brewed the tea she would not drink. She stepped over the floorboard. And at a quarter past seven, while she was standing in the back room with her coat still on and her hands still inked from Wren's iron-gall ink, the bell of the actual shop rang, and she heard the voice before she saw the face.

"Callie? It's Gus. Hope I'm not too late for a browse."

Augustus Ralston came through the stacks toward her with the easy unhurried gait of a man entering a room he partly owned, and he was carrying a paper bag from the bakery on the square and a warmth that preceded him like the heat from an open oven. "I heard you'd closed up early today. Wanted to make sure you were eating. Mae told me — well, Mae tells everyone, you know Mae." He set the bag on the counter. A loaf of sourdough, still warm. "How are you holding up, sweetheart?"

Callie looked at the loaf. She looked at his face. She could not find the seam in the concern; it sat on him as naturally as the cashmere of his sweater, as if it had been made for him, as if there were no version of Gus Ralston that was not, in this moment, genuinely worried about her.

"I'm alright, Mr. Ralston."

"Gus." He smiled, and the smile was the same seamless, well-rehearsed thing it had been at the auction. "Awful business. Awful. Wendell was — well. You knew him better than I did, I think. We were all fond of him at the Society. He'd come round to lecture sometimes, you know. Brilliant man. Scattered as a March wind, but brilliant." He shook his head, and the sorrow in it was so well-shaped that Callie almost admired the craft of it. "I keep thinking about all the work he had going. All those years of research. It'd be a tragedy if it just — evaporated, wouldn't it?"

His hands were on the counter. They were resting there, perfectly still, as he spoke. Callie looked at them.

She had looked at hands all her professional life. She had read hands for twenty years — the hurried hand and the careful hand, the hand that pressed hard and the hand that barely touched the page. She knew what control looked like, and she knew what it cost. Gus Ralston's hands were the hands of a man holding something down. They did not tremble. They did not shift. They lay on the oak with the absolute, effortful stillness of a thing that had been commanded to be still, and the effort of the commanding was, to a woman who read hands, louder than any tremor would have been.

"Pike kept his research at the archives," she said, evenly. "I imagine the county has it now."

"Of course. Of course they do." He nodded, easy, and there was the smallest pause — the length of a held breath — before he went on. "It's just, you hear things. People say he had notes all over town, copies, that sort of thing. Unfinished work, you know. In unreliable hands, that kind of

material can do a lot of damage. Not to the dead — the dead are past it. To the living." He met her eyes, and for a half-second the warmth in his face had a floor under it, something hard and level and measuring. "You'd tell me, Callie. If you knew where any of it had gone. So it could be properly archived."

The question was not a question. Callie heard the shape of what he was actually asking — not in the words themselves but in the spaces the words had been chosen to leave, the way a cipher hides in the gap between two honest lines. She heard it as concern. She answered it as concern.

"I don't," she said. "I'm sorry, Gus. If I hear anything, I'll bring it straight to you."

"Good girl." He touched her shoulder — the light patron's touch, brief and warm — and left the sourdough on the counter and let himself out, and the bell rang behind him, and the shop was quiet.

Callie stood where she was. She looked at the loaf, still warm, and at the counter where his hands had lain, and she could not have said what was wrong. Only that a detail in the warm baritone of his voice had not matched the register of concern — a mark that did not belong to the hand — and that she had set it aside, under a heading she could not yet read, and that it would keep.

Properly archived. She turned the phrase over, looking for what it had been chosen to hide. Archivists did not speak of a colleague's notes that way. There had been no *if* in his asking — only the shape of where he wanted her answer to go. And that held breath before it, the length of a single held breath, which she had heard and could not yet read. She was standing in the shop with a stranger's warm bread on her counter and the taste of bergamot gone wrong in her throat, and the cipher would not close, and she did not know why.

She did not eat the bread. She wrapped it, later, and left it on Mae's porch. The rain had stopped for the first time in three days, and the square outside the windows was dark and still and wet, and somewhere across it, in a house on the hill, a man whose hands did not tremble was sitting down to his dinner. She stood a long time at the dark window and did not turn her back on the square, and the held breath she could not yet read would not leave her, and she did not know why.

CHAPTER FOUR: THE ESCALATION

The Escalation

She found the murder on a Wednesday morning, in the back third of the 1843 ledger, in a margin no wider than her thumb.

She had been two days at it. The notes had been getting darker as she worked deeper into the volume — Wren's hand tightening, the abbreviations crowding, the cipher layer thickening where the surveyor had most feared being read. She had learned, over those two days, to read his fear: in the pressure of the nib, in the words he crossed out and rewrote, in the stretches where the Latin gave way to the private cipher because the thing he was setting down was too dangerous to say in any tongue a clerk might recognize. The survey lines had been the beginning. The land transfers had been the middle. This, in the back of the 1843 ledger, was what lay underneath.

She had Eleanor's glass in her hand. She did not remember picking it up. It sat in her palm warm from her grip, the brass of it the same temperature as her skin, and the margin was all that held — four inches, a dead language, what a frightened man had seen. Somewhere above her a door opened and closed in the town hall, and a draft stirred the basement air, and she was conscious, for one beat, of how alone she was in a room with what had gotten a man killed.

Minister moriturus. Equus, via nota. Non casus.

The minister about to die. A horse. A known road. Not an accident.

The cipher beneath it resisted her at first. She tried it as a date, then as a bearing-correction — the habits she had taught herself on the easier notes — and it would not read either way. It was not a number at all. She sat back, breathed, and tried it as a name; and the name came. She thought, with a small cold drop, of the six pages torn from Pike's manuscript, and understood now what those pages had been translating. This was the source. She pressed the glass closer and read the name letter by letter, one shape at a time: *S.R. iussit* — Silas Ralston ordered it.

She did not move. The rest of the room fell away — the hum, the cold stone — until there was nothing but the shape of those three letters and the verb that followed them, and the meaning settling in, slow and final.

Reverend Thomas Hartwell — Mae's ancestor, the town's minister — had found the fraud. Days later he was dead, thrown from a horse on a road he had ridden a thousand times. The magistrate had ruled it an accident. The magistrate, Wren's note went on to specify in the cipher beneath, *iudex emptus*, the magistrate bought.

She had to set the glass down for a moment, because the hand had changed. Down here, at the bottom of the margin, Wren's careful small letters had come apart. The nib had torn the paper in two places where he bore down too hard. He had written Silas Ralston's name in full — not the initials he used everywhere else, but the whole name, *Silas Ralston*, as if the caution of the cipher had finally given way under the weight of what he was setting down — and then he had gone back and tried to score it out, and the scoring was half-hearted, the kind of scratching-out a man does when he knows he ought to hide a name and cannot bring himself to. The nib had splintered on the last stroke. There was a place where the ink had bled where his hand had stopped, and held, and shaken — a surveyor setting down the only testimony he could, in the only language that

would outlive the men who would kill him for it. He had wanted it found. He had wanted it found even as he hid it. Callie understood that, suddenly: he had written it for a reader who had not been born yet.

The riding accident had been staged. The minister had not died by accident. And the man who had ordered it was the same man whose stolen land had built the house on the hill, the same man whose name was on the plaques, the same man whose descendant had stood at Callie's counter two nights ago and offered her sourdough and asked, in a warm baritone, about unreliable hands.

She gripped the glass until the brass bit into her fingers.

The word came to her in Wren's voice, across the century and a half between his hand and her eye — the word he had not been able to leave unspoken and had not dared to speak plainly — the word Pike had been reaching for and that the town had spent a hundred and eighty years not saying:

Killed.

The sentence snapped. The room came back — the cold, the hum, the weight of the stone — and Callie sat in Pike's chair and understood, finally and completely, why someone had poisoned his tea.

She sat for a long time. She thought about the long unbroken chain of bought magistrates and quiet silences and adjusted cuff links that connected that 1843 morning to this one. She thought about Pike sitting in this same chair, reading this same note, understanding this same thing, and then pouring himself a cup of bergamot tea and not knowing that the cup had already been poured for him. She closed the ledger. She laid her hand flat on the cover, over the place where Wren's hand must have rested when he shut the book for the last time, and she held it there until the leather was warm.

She went home and slept badly. The next morning her key did not work.

She stood at the archive door and tried it twice, certain she was doing something wrong, and then a third time with the deliberate slowness of a woman who suspects the lock and not herself. The clerk — a young man from the county office she did not know well — appeared at the end of the hall, apologetic already, a young man with rehearsed news.

"Ms. Thorne? I'm sorry. There's been — your access is under review. Town council decision, effective yesterday. Pending the investigation." He held out a printed notice in a folder, as if the folder made it less of a thing. "It's about preserving evidence, the letter says. Materials relevant to an active case. I'm real sorry. You can appeal to the council."

Callie took the folder. She did not open it. She did not need to. *Pending review. Effective yesterday*. The words of a machine. Gus had not signed the letter. Gus never signed anything. Gus funded things, and the things he funded moved on their own, and by the time the movement reached Callie's key it wore the face of procedure.

She turned to go, and there he was.

He had timed it perfectly, the way he timed everything — arriving at the precise moment that looked like coincidence to anyone who wasn't counting. He came up the town hall steps with his hat in his hand and a concerned wrinkle between his brows, and he saw her and stopped as if she were the last person he'd expected.

"Callie." The wrinkle deepened. "I heard about the archive business. I'm sure it's just temporary — they're being careful, that's all. A man's dead, and the council wants to keep the records clean for the sheriff." He put a hand on her elbow, light, guiding, the touch of a man walking a lady across a street. "You know how these things are. Give it a week. It'll blow over."

"Of course," Callie said. "I'm sure it will."

"Good girl." The smile, the perfect smile. "You've been under such strain. Let other people carry it for a while."

He left her at the top of the steps and went into the town hall, and Callie stood in the cold morning light and watched him go, and she did not need to read his hand or his voice to know what she had just seen. She would not fold. And standing there on the cold steps, she understood the leash he had always held — not the key to the archives, which was a thing that could be taken back, but the scanner he had paid for and the climate-control unit he had funded and the council goodwill that kept the lights on in her basement. He had bought the room she worked in. He had bought it years ago, with a check and a smile, and she had taken the gift without ever reading the invoice. She tucked the folder under her arm and walked home through the square, and on the way she passed the barbershop and the post office and the bench under the old oak where the retired men sat, and on every face she caught the small sliding-away look of a town that had begun to know, without anyone saying it aloud, that Callie Thorne was pulling at a thread. She caught a fragment from the bench as she passed — one of the retired men saying something about the Fenns, how one of them had been down at the county records office asking about old land grants. She filed it without breaking stride. Everyone had a reason to be curious about the past, all of a sudden. Everyone had a thread they wanted to pull or keep buried.

The word on the square, by the afternoon, was that Sheriff Cross was bringing the Townsend boy in. Not arrested yet. Not yet. But the geometry was closing — the argument, the empty alibi, the nervousness that read as guilt — and Callie could feel the wrong man's case assembling itself, link by link.

She thought of Eli as she had last seen him — the hoodie strings twisted to a rope between his fingers, the dark circles under his eyes, the way he had flinched at her voice before he had even registered who she was. He had been expecting to be blamed for something his whole short life. He was about to be.

She was standing behind her own counter, where the lamp was warm and the shop smelled the way it always had, of leather and old paper, turning over the unfairness of having every door close at once, when the bell rang and Mae Hartwell came in.

Mae did not bring soup. Mae brought herself, in her good cardigan, with her silver hair done, and she did not browse the shelves or straighten anything with her busy hands. She stood in the middle of the shop and she looked at Callie, and the look had no softness in it at all.

"Come to the house tonight," Mae said. "There's something I need to tell you. And I won't say it here."

Callie went.

The Hartwell kitchen was warm and close and smelled of lavender and bread and the faint sweet decay of apples in a bowl. Through the doorway she could see the parlor, and on its shelf a worn family Bible, spine cracked, a bookmark of faded ribbon holding a place someone had not closed.

Mae moved through the kitchen — gathering, stirring, setting out — but her hands were the busiest Callie had ever seen them, and the busier they were, the more Callie understood what the busyness was for. She set a cup of tea in front of Callie — not bergamot; chamomile; a small mercy — and sat down across the oak table and folded her hands over the place where the rolling pin usually lay, and for a long moment she did not speak.

Then she said, "My grandmother told me a story, once."

Her voice was the unhurried cadence Callie knew, but the melody under it had changed. There was no gardening metaphor. There was no *honey*. The words came out plain.

"She told it to me in this kitchen. She closed the door first, like the walls could hear. She told it in a voice I had never heard her use — low, and flat, and final, the voice of a woman saying a thing once because she would not say it twice. She said the Ralstons took the land. She said they took it from us, and from the Tuckers, and from the Fenns, and from two other families whose names I've forgotten because I was young and I didn't want to remember. She said a minister in our family found out. She said he died for it." Mae looked down at her folded hands. "She never said the word murder. She didn't have to. I was nine years old, and I understood her anyway."

The kitchen was very quiet. The clock on the wall ticked. Outside, the rain had started again — Callie hadn't noticed it start — and it tapped the Hartwell windows with the patient sound she had always, in every other room of her life, read as safety. Here, in this kitchen, with Mae's hands still over the rolling-pin place, the sound was only rain.

"I never told anyone," Mae said. "Not my husband, God rest him. Not my children. I told myself it was to protect them. I told myself the past was the past, and that dragging it up would only hurt people who'd had no part in it, and that the Lord knew the truth and that was enough." She looked up, and her eyes were dry and very clear. "I have told myself that story for fifty years, Callie. I have made it the furniture of my life. And now you are sitting in my kitchen pulling at the thread, and I am asking you — I am asking you, with everything I have — to leave it where it lies."

Callie set down the cup she had not drunk from. The chamomile trembled, a single ring, and went still.

"Mae."

"Don't." The word came out soft, and it stopped Callie's mouth the way a hand would have. "Don't tell me you have to. I know you have to. I've watched you for two years not have to do anything, and now you have to do this, and I know what it means. I know what it'll do to this town. I know what it'll do to my grandchildren, who play every afternoon on a field that was our family's before the paper said it wasn't. I know what it'll do to the Tuckers, who've been renting their own land from the county for four generations and don't even know it. I know, Callie." Her voice did not crack. It went quiet. "I am asking you to let the dead keep their secret. Not for the Ralstons. For everyone else."

There was something under the plea. Callie could feel it — not seen, but there, a second shape pressed into the first, the way a watermark hides in good paper. Mae was asking for the town, and the grandchildren, and the families who had had no part in it; and Mae was also, in some room she would not let herself enter, asking to be left in the quiet she had built her whole life inside. Callie heard all of that, or nearly all of it. She heard it, in the end, as love.

The kitchen clock ticked. The rain tapped. And Callie sat across the table from the closest thing she had to family and understood that she was about to do the thing she could not undo.

"I can't," she said.

Mae did not move.

"I can't, Mae. I have read what Jacob Wren wrote. I have read what Pike died for. The sheriff is about to arrest a boy who flinches when anyone speaks to him, because the boy is the wrong shape and the real killer wears the right name. If I stop now, Eli Townsend goes to prison. And the man behind the lock on my archive door — I think I know who he is, Mae. I think he did worse than lock a door." She kept her voice level. It cost her. "I am not trying to hurt anyone. I am trying not to let the dead be the only ones who know."

Mae's hands, which had been moving all evening — stirring, folding, gripping — went still. They lay on the oak like two small sleeping animals, and the stillness of them was so complete and so unlike her that Callie felt the hair rise on her own arms.

"You sound like your mother," Mae said, very quietly. "She would have said it just like that."

The words landed, and Callie did not know if they were a compliment or an indictment, and she suspected Mae did not know either.

Mae stood. She did not embrace her. She moved around the table and paused at Callie's shoulder, and for a moment her hand came up as if to touch Callie's hair, the way she had touched it a thousand times, and then the hand thought better of it and went back to her side. She walked Callie to the door, and at the door she said, "I'll bring soup tomorrow," in a voice that meant she would. Callie nodded because there was nothing else to do.

She walked home in the rain. It was a soft rain, the kind that did not so much fall as hang in the air, and by the time she reached the square her coat was damp and her hair was flat and there was a smell on her she could not place at first — sweet, herbal, clinging to the wool at her shoulder where Mae had almost touched her and then not. Lavender. Mae's lavender, pressed into the fibers of her coat the way ink presses into paper, the kind of smell that would not come out in one washing, or two, that would linger in the weave long after the evening was over.

She let herself into the shop. She stepped over the floorboard. In the dark back room, with Eleanor's glass on its felt rest and the rain on the windows, the lavender would not leave her — Mae's mercy and Mae's cost pressed into the same wool. She did not brew the tea. Across town, a boy who flinched at loud voices was being fitted for a crime he had not committed, and the man who had done it sat on a council that had already taken her key. The archives were closed. But Gus Ralston had paid for another room full of records — the Historical Society, where the stacks bore his family's name. She stood a long time in the dark, breathing the lavender in, and began to think about where to look next.

CHAPTER FIVE: THE SQUEEZE

The Squeeze

She could not get into the archives. So she went to the place Gus Ralston had paid for instead.

She had said *I can't* to the closest thing she had to family twelve hours ago, and the lavender was still in the shoulder of her coat, and she did not let herself think about that either.

The Blackwood Ridge Historical Society sat in a restored Victorian two streets off the square, its gingerbread trim painted the green of old money, its foundation plaque bearing the Ralston name in letters an inch deep. Callie had always found the irony of the place useful, the way a lockpicker finds a window useful: the Society collected the town's history, which meant it also held it, and what it held was, in theory, open to anyone with a research interest and a signature. She signed the visitor's register at the front desk — the bound leather book, the same kind the archives kept — and went up to the collections room, and she did not let herself think about the fact that she was walking into the killer's own house to look for the thing he had killed to hide.

She knew roughly what she was looking for, because she knew what Pike had been looking for. The keystone. The single annotated source from which every other margin note in his manuscript descended — the book Jacob Wren had marked most heavily before he fled town, the one Pike had been working from. Pike had told her, once, that he believed it had been donated to a local collection decades ago, before anyone knew what it was. *Hiding in plain sight,* he had said, with the small excited smile of a man who loved the phrase. She had not understood, then, how dangerous plain sight could be.

The collections room smelled of furniture wax and the faint chemical sweetness of preservation spray. Callie worked the stacks methodically — by era, by donor, by the small telltale signs of a book that had been handled too much for its apparent importance. It was easier to work than to think; her hands knew the old order, and she let them keep it, and the dread sat underneath the method where she did not have to look at it. She found it in the third cabinet, in a lot donated by the Ralston estate in 1962: a slim, clothbound volume of regional survey records, undated, its spine cracked from use, its pages soft at the edges. An ordinary book. She opened it, and the margins were full.

Wren's hand. Wren's hand at its most desperate. The cipher here was not buried under Latin; it was buried under a private variant of the cipher she had cracked at the archives, and she sat down at the reading table, took out Eleanor's glass, and worked through it. Not to learn what it said — she already knew that; she had read the accusation in the 1843 ledger two days ago. She worked through it because this was the source, the original in Wren's own hand, and she needed her own copy of it before it could vanish the way the six pages had vanished.

She worked backward from the one phrase she was certain of, and the rest gave in stages — the surveyor's marks, the Latin contractions, then the substitution layer she untied one letter at a time. The hand grew worse as it went; the nib had torn the paper in two places, and the final page was written at a slant, the letters crowding each other for room. By the end of the second hour she had the whole of it, and it said exactly what she already knew it would say: the true survey lines, the forged filings, and the five families whose land had been rolled into the Ralston grant — the Tuckers, the Fenns, the Coles, the Marrs, the Hartwells, all five named now where Mae

could remember only three. And at the bottom of the final page, in a hand that shook so badly the letters nearly fell over each other, the surveyor's farewell: *I have written it here because I cannot write it anywhere a living man will read it, and I am leaving tonight, and I pray God someone finds this who can do what I cannot.*

Callie closed the book. She laid her hand on the cover. She sat with it for a long moment — not the shock of discovery, but the weight of holding the original, the page a man had died trying to bring to light — and then she opened her notebook and began, carefully, to copy the cipher and its translation in her own hand, because the original could disappear, and she would not be left with nothing.

Then she went back downstairs, and she opened the visitor's register, and she read it.

She had not known what she was looking for until she found it. The names were unremarkable — researchers, genealogists, the occasional town councilman — and then, three days before Gus's entry, a name that stopped her: *J. Fenn — genealogical research.* Fenn. One of the five families Wren had named. Callie stared at it. A descendant of the robbed, coming to look at the same records Pike had been working from. Had they known? Had they come looking for the truth on their own — or had they come to make sure no one else found it? The Fenns had carried the shame for generations. Shame was its own kind of motive.

She turned the page, and the Fenn lead dissolved. The timing didn't work. J. Fenn had visited three days before Gus, a week before Pike — before Pike had shown his findings to anyone, before anyone living knew what the margins contained. Fenn had been chasing ghosts, the same as Pike, from the other side of the theft. She set it aside.

Two entries later, in a hand she knew from a hundred signed checks and a thousand foundation plaques: *A. Ralston — collection review.* Collection review. Eight days before Pike died. Gus Ralston had walked into the building he funded, and walked up to the room where the keystone lived in plain sight in a cabinet his family had donated, and he had *reviewed the collection.* He had sat where she was sitting now. He had read what she had just read. And he had understood exactly what it meant, and exactly who was about to make it public. He had left the keystone where it lay, because a catalogued Society lot could not vanish without a paper trail, and because he believed — as the town had believed for a hundred and eighty years — that no one living could read it.

Callie turned the page. There, two days later: *Dr. W. Pike — research.* And beside the entry, in the margin, in Pike's own excited pencil — because the Society let its regulars annotate the register the way they annotated everything — *showed preliminary findings to Gus Ralston — very interested, asked to see the manuscript. Good. The book deserves daylight.*

The page trembled under her hand. She set the register down. She read the line again, and a third time — the eager shorthand of a man who had been *glad*, who had thought the interest of a patron was a gift and not a survey of the threat, who had noted it thoroughly, date-stamped, blind. Pike had walked Gus Ralston through his own death warrant and shaken his hand afterward and brewed himself a cup of tea.

The sequence locked, step by step: Gus had learned of the manuscript. Gus had come to the Society to see what Pike was working from. Gus had asked to see the manuscript, and Pike, trusting, had shown him. Gus had read the truth of his own family. And Gus had decided, in

the calm deliberate way he decided everything, that the truth was worth a man's life. Six pages missing from the archives. One cup of poisoned tea. One steady pair of hands on her counter.

She copied the register entries into her notebook. She returned the keystone to its cabinet. She signed out of the Society and walked, almost ran, the three blocks to the Ridgeway Auction House.

The back office was still taped, but the main floor was open for a cataloguing day, and Eli Townsend was alone at the long display table with an armful of lots and the hunched shoulders of a man trying to be invisible in his own workplace. He flinched when he saw her. He had been flinching for days, she realized; it was the flinch of a man who had begun to expect the worst from every direction and could not stop bracing for it.

"Ms. Thorne. Hi. Sorry. I didn't — the back office is still, um, closed, so if you were looking for—"

"I'm not looking at the back office, Eli." She kept her voice the way she kept her hands around a brittle page — level, slow, unthreatening. "I'm looking for a book. A novel. You borrowed one from the stacks here, a while back, and brought it back the night of the auction. Do you know where it is now?"

The color left his face. She watched the calculation move across it — the impulse to deny, the worse impulse to confess to something larger than he'd done, the miserable tangle of both at once. His hands went to his hoodie string and pulled.

"I — it was just a paperback. I didn't think anyone would care. I brought it back during the auction because I thought everyone would be out front. I could just — put it back and nobody would notice." He stopped. Swallowed. "It's probably still wherever I left it. I shoved it on the wrong shelf. By the back office. I was in a hurry."

Callie found it herself, three minutes later, on a shelf of auction-house reference volumes where no paperback belonged — a dog-eared mystery novel, its spine cracked from being read on a bus, slipped in spine-out among the clothbound lots. She stopped before touching it, took out her phone, and photographed the book in place with the shelf mark and surrounding volumes visible. Eli made a small wrecked sound, the sound of a man watching the small ashamed thing he'd done turn into the explanation for something he hadn't.

She left the book where it was. She did not say *this clears you*. She did not say *you were in the building where a man died*. She looked at him — at the dark circles under his eyes, at the hoodie string twisted to a rope between his fingers, at the particular exhaustion of a young man who had been expecting to be blamed for this his whole life — and she saw, with a clarity that hurt, exactly the kind of person she had spent her career trying to pull out of the margins. An ordinary person. About to be erased by a history that had nothing to do with him.

"Eli." She waited until he met her eyes, which took a long time. "You're going to be all right. I'm going to make sure of it. But I need you to trust me, and I need you to not talk to the sheriff again until I tell you to. Can you do that?"

He nodded, a small dumb grateful nod, the nod of a man who had never in his life been told someone would make sure of it. She put the phone back in her bag — the photograph, the corroboration, the small dog-eared thing that explained why he had been near the corridor.

She was halfway to the door when he said her name.

"Ms. Thorne?"

She turned back. Eli was standing where she'd left him, but something had shifted in his face — the fidgeting had stopped, and what was underneath it was worse than the fidgeting. He was working up to something. She waited.

"The night of the auction," he said. "When I was leaving the back stacks. After I put the book back, I mean." He swallowed. "I saw Mr. Ralston. Coming out of the back corridor. The one by the offices."

The room went very quiet.

"He came out right as I was putting the book on the shelf. Nearly walked into me. And he — he looked at me, and he nodded, like everything was normal. And I thought, okay. Everything's fine. And then about ten minutes later—" He stopped. His hands had gone still at his sides. "I didn't tell the sheriff. I didn't tell anyone. I was already — I thought if I said I was back there, near the offices, they'd think—"

"I know, Eli." She kept her voice level, but something had locked into place behind her sternum — a cold clean click, the sound of a tumbler turning. "I know exactly what they'd think. But you're going to tell the sheriff. I'll be there. And this time, he's going to listen."

Eli looked at her. He nodded again — not the grateful nod this time, but something steadier, the nod of a man deciding to trust someone for the first time in his life.

She left him standing in the warm empty auction house and walked home through the square with the notebook pressed against her ribs, and the whole town felt like a hand closing around her, and she understood that the only remaining question was whether she would use what she had.

The bell rang at a quarter to nine.

She was in the back room, the notebook open on the oak table beside Eleanor's glass. She had laid the evidence out in the order she would later lay it out for Cross: Wren's decoded cipher from the keystone, her own transcription of the surveyor's prayer, the visitor's entries showing Gus's name eight days before the murder and Pike's two days later, Pike's eager margin note about Gus Ralston, and the photograph of the dog-eared paperback where it remained on the wrong shelf, corroborating Eli's reason for being near the back corridor. Laid end to end, in this order, they were a rope. She was looking at the rope when the front door opened, and she heard the careful step, and the voice.

"Callie? You still up?"

He let himself in. He had never let himself in before. The key to the shop was a town-council key, the kind that opened any lock on the square, and he used it now as if it were his right, and the using of it was the first true thing he had shown her. She came out from the back room and found him standing in the center of her shop, his hat in his hands, and for one disorienting moment he looked exactly as he had always looked — the warm baritone, the concerned wrinkle, the man who wrote the checks that saved the buildings.

"Callie." He did not come closer. "You've been under such strain."

"Mr. Ralston."

"Gus." The automatic correction, but softer now, and he did not smile. "I worry about you. All this running around, the archives, the Society today — I hear things." He set his hat on her counter,

the way Cross had set his hat on her counter, and the echo of it was not lost on her. “A woman in your position has a great deal to lose. The lease on this building comes up next year. The scanner in your back room — I signed that check, Callie. Eight thousand dollars’ worth of my goodwill, sitting on your shelf.”

He paused. The pause had a floor under it.

“I’d hate to see anything happen to this shop.” He was looking at the shelves, not at her. “Your mother kept it beautifully. She knew when a thing was worth protecting and when it was worth leaving alone. She understood that some threads, once you pull them, don’t stop unraveling. Not for anyone.”

“You knew my mother.”

“I knew her well. She was a careful woman.” He turned, and looked at her, and the warmth was gone from his face. Not replaced — gone, as if it had been a lamp and someone had unscrewed the bulb. What was left was the architecture underneath, and the architecture was older than he was. “Wendell didn’t know when to stop, Callie. Terrible thing. He was a brilliant man, and he could not leave a matter settled, and it cost him.” He held her gaze. “I would so hate to see what happened to Wendell happen to someone else.”

She looked at his hands.

They were on the counter, where they had been the other night, but they were not still now. They were trembling. A fine, constant tremor — the over-control finally failing him, here, now, in this room, under the weight of being seen. She watched it, reading the pressure beneath the control, the effort that the control was built to conceal. He saw her see it. His mouth tightened, and for one half-second the mask came off entirely, and she was looking at the portrait in the town hall — the patriarch’s flat measuring stare, the same eyes, the same set jaw, Silas Ralston looking out through the descendant’s face a hundred and eighty years later — and she understood, in her body before she understood it in her mind, that she was looking at the man who had killed Pike, and that he had come here tonight to tell her so, and that he was deciding, in the length of that held silence, whether he would have to do it again.

Neither of them spoke. The truth sat between them on the counter, next to his hat, as plain as a cup of cold tea, and neither of them named it, because naming it would make it real and neither of them — not the woman who had spent her life among the dead, not the man who had spent his life burying them — was ready for it to be real.

Callie said nothing. She was reading him, and he could see that she was reading him, and that was the thing that had changed between them: not the threat, which had always been there, but his understanding that she had learned to read it.

“Think about what I’ve said,” Gus said, finally, and his voice was almost warm again, almost, the bulb screwed back in but not quite seated. He picked up his hat. “Good night, Callie.”

He let himself out. The bell rang. The lock caught.

It was the leaving that was strangest — that he had come, and shown her, and gone again without doing the thing a part of her had expected. He had decided something in the length of that held silence, and the decision had been to wait. Callie stood in the middle of her own shop and listened to his steps cross the square and fade, and she did not move for a long time, and when she finally

moved it was to step over the floorboard and go into the back room and stand in the dark where her mother had died. The room smelled of leather and old paper and, faintly, of bergamot, and the smell that had always been her sanctuary smelled, tonight, like a place a person could be found in. Like a place a person could be left.

She understood, now, what Pike had felt in his last weeks — the cold of being watched by a man who had not yet decided. She stood in Eleanor's room with Eleanor's glass on the table and the notebook of the dead pressed against her ribs. The notebook that would keep Eli Townsend out of a cell. Keeping him out had become, sometime in the last hour, the reason a man had stood in her shop deciding whether she lived.

She sat down at the oak table in the dark without turning on the light. For a moment her hand found Eleanor's glass where it lay on the felt — her weapon, the dead's instrument — and then her body did the thing her mind refused to: she heard, with a new and terrible precision, every sound the shop made — the tick of the cooling pipes, the creak of the front floorboard under no one's weight, the wind testing the window latch. Her hands, folded on the table in front of her, would not stay still. She pressed them flat, the way she pressed a curling page, and they trembled against the oak, and she let them tremble, because there was no one here to see and because the trembling was the truest thing she had felt in two years. She sat with it. She waited for morning, and the whole night through she did not once stop being afraid.

CHAPTER SIX: THE DECISION

The Decision

She had not slept. The trembling in her hands had not stopped, not through the long hours after he left, not through the dark in Eleanor's room where she sat at the oak table with the evidence laid out in front of her and her body refusing to believe the room was safe. The shop had its sounds — the tick of the cooling pipes, the creak of the front floorboard under no one's weight, the wind testing the window latch in the back — and every one of them had kept her awake, because the last time she had stopped listening to sounds in the dark was two years ago, and she had found her mother on the floor.

By the time Callie opened the shop the next morning, the talk on the square was that Sheriff Cross was bringing the Townsend boy in before lunch. They had the argument. They had the nerves. They had an unexplained gap in his story and a roomful of witnesses who had watched the boy act exactly the way a guilty man acts, because they had never learned, and Cross had never learned, that a frightened man acts that way too.

Callie stood behind her counter and listened to the talk arrive in the shape of a customer who bought a postcard and stayed fifteen minutes to deliver it, and she felt the last minutes of Eli Townsend's freedom ticking down in the cadence of a stranger's voice. She had hours. Maybe less. She had a notebook, a transcribed cipher, photographs of a dog-eared paperback, and the certain knowledge that the man who had actually done it was, at this moment, sitting down to coffee somewhere on the hill.

She closed the shop. She turned the sign to CLOSED and locked the door. Her hands were not steady on the key. She stepped over the floorboard and went into the back room and closed the door and stood for a long moment in the quiet of Eleanor's room, breathing the leather and the old paper and the faint ghost of bergamot, and she laid the evidence out on the oak table in the order she had laid it out the night before, beside the brass magnifying glass on its felt rest.

The room was the room it had always been. Eleanor's workspace. Eleanor's deathplace. She was going to leave it today. She knew that the way she knew the weather, in the pressure of the air before the storm, and the knowing pressed against the boards under her feet, because this was the room where she had chosen the dead for two years, and she was about to choose otherwise.

She opened the bottom drawer of the archive table.

They were there, where they had always been, in the soft leather case Eleanor had kept them in: the reading glasses, the ones that had been on the table the night Eleanor died. Callie had put them in the drawer two years ago and had not opened the drawer since. She took the case out now and set it on the oak and opened it, and the glasses were exactly as she remembered them — the tortoiseshell frames, the little nose pads, the faint smudge on the right lens that Eleanor had never quite cleaned. They smelled faintly of her, or Callie's memory insisted they did, which was the same thing.

She picked them up. She unfolded them. And, because she was about to do the thing her mother had never been able to do, and because some part of her needed to know whether Eleanor's hand would guide her through it, she put them on.

They did not fit.

They sat wrong on her nose, the prescription wrong for her eyes, the arms too tight at her temples, the whole weight of them wrong in a way that had nothing to do with optometry. She had known they would not fit. She had known it as she knew the floorboard creaked. But she had needed to put them on, once, and feel them sit wrong, and understand in her body that she was not Eleanor, that she had never been Eleanor, that the inheritance she had been carrying was not a destiny but a choice, and that she could set it down.

She took the glasses off. She put them back in the case. She closed the case and put it back in the drawer. She did not cry. She did not feel relief.

On the table, the evidence waited. The brass magnifying glass caught the grey morning light, warm from the room the way it had always been warm. She looked at it — the instrument of her gift, balanced for a woman's hand — and for the first time in two years it did not pull at her. She picked it up.

She heard Eleanor's voice, the way she always heard it when she touched the glass: *The truth is always there, Callie. Most people just don't look closely enough.* She had carried that line like a talisman. She had repeated it to herself in the dark hours after Eleanor died, and she had believed it meant comfort, and then she had believed it meant professional pride, and now — standing in the room where she was about to walk into the living world and burn her own fortress down — it sounded like a weight. It sounded like a woman handing a child a burden and calling it a gift, and the child taking it because the child loved the woman, and carrying it, and carrying it, until the child forgot it was possible to set it down.

She could hear the rain. It had started in the night and it had not stopped, tapping the back room windows — the patient sound she had always read as safety, of being inside while the world stayed outside. She listened to it now, and the safety was gone out of it, and the outside was pressing in at the glass.

She set the magnifying glass down on the oak, beside the evidence, and let go of it, and her hand came away empty. She did not put it back on its felt rest. She stood over it for a long moment and let the meaning of what she had done settle into her hands and her shoulders and the set of her jaw. The alternative was a boy in a cell and a killer on a hill and another generation of a town built on a lie.

The lavender was still on the shoulder of her coat from two nights ago, from Mae's kitchen, from the last time someone had touched her with something other than fear. She did not touch it now. She gathered the notebook. She gathered the transcriptions, the register pages, and the photographs. She did not take the glass. She left the shop by the front door, and she did not look back at the room she was leaving, and she crossed the square in the rain with her evidence pressed against her ribs, and she went into the sheriff's office, and she closed the door behind her.

Cross was at his desk. He had his hat off, and his jacket hung on the chair, and there was a file open in front of him with Eli Townsend's name on the tab. He looked up when the door opened, and the flatness of his expression said he'd already used up his patience for the day.

"Ms. Thorne. I'm busy."

"I know you're about to arrest Eli Townsend." She did not sit when he did not offer. She stood on the other side of his desk, and she kept her voice level, because the voice was the one thing she could still control. "I'm asking you to give me twenty minutes before you do."

"Twenty minutes."

"It's going to change what the evidence is." She set the notebook on his desk, on top of the file with Eli's name. "Twenty minutes. If I'm wrong, you've lost twenty minutes. If I'm right, you were about to put an innocent man in that cell you keep polished."

Something moved behind his eyes. He looked at the notebook. He looked at her. Then he leaned back in his chair, and he crossed his arms, and he did not say yes, but he did not say go, and in the language of Dalton Cross that was a yes.

She started with the register. She turned to the pages she had copied from the Historical Society's visitor log — *A. Ralston, collection review,* eight days before the auction; *Dr. W. Pike, research,* two days later; and Pike's own eager pencil in the margin, *showed preliminary findings to Gus Ralston — very interested, asked to see the manuscript.* She set them on the desk beside his file. "Augustus Ralston signed into the building he funded eight days before Pike died. He asked to see the manuscript. Pike trusted him. Pike showed it to him."

Cross's jaw tightened. He flipped to the next page. "This is a library sign-in sheet, Ms. Thorne. Not a confession."

"It puts him in the room with the manuscript eight days before Pike died. Now the murder itself." She turned to the cipher transcription — the true survey line, the forged one, the hundred and forty acres that had walked from the Hartwell grant to the Ralston holdings on the strength of a lie. "The Ralston name is on the plaques, Sheriff. It's on the library wing, and the checks that fund your budget. If what Pike found came out, the land claims could be challenged in court. The families who lost their land could sue." She let that land. "The Ralston name becomes the descendant of a thief and a murderer. That is not an old land dispute. That is the end of a man's world. Men have killed for less."

"Motive isn't murder." Cross shifted in his chair. "Half this town has a reason to want something kept quiet. That doesn't put poison in a cup."

"It's motive joined to access." She leaned forward. "You saw the cup on the floor the night he died. Bergamot. Pike drank it every session — you had that in your notes. Someone who knew that habit and had time alone with him in that corridor. The Townsend boy didn't know what Dr. Pike drank. He doesn't know what anyone drinks. He can't make eye contact long enough to find out."

"And the boy's reason for being back there?"

She set her phone on the desk with the photograph open. "Eli Townsend was in the back stacks the night of the murder. He didn't tell you because he was ashamed, and because he's spent his whole life expecting to be blamed for things. He was returning a novel he'd borrowed without asking. He put it on the wrong shelf by the back office during the auction and went back to the main floor. I photographed it exactly where he left it. Send a deputy. It is still there."

Cross picked up the phone. He enlarged the photograph with his thumb, studying the shelf mark and the volumes around the paperback, then set it down again.

"There's one more thing," Callie said. "Eli Townsend saw Augustus Ralston coming out of the back office corridor the night of the auction. Minutes before the body was found."

Cross's pen stopped.

"The boy saw him."

"The boy saw him. He didn't tell you because he was terrified — and because every time someone in authority has looked at Eli Townsend, they've seen what they expected to see. But he'll tell you now. I asked him to wait."

Cross was quiet for a moment. Then he reached for the file with Eli's name on it, not the notebook — his own file, his own notes — and flipped to a page. "Staff entrance log has Ralston signing out at seven-twelve. Body wasn't found until seven-twenty-one." He said it to himself, not to her, tracing the timeline with his thumb. "If the boy saw him in the corridor, and the log puts him leaving before the alarm was raised—"

"That's your case, Sheriff. Not mine. I'm just the woman who reads the margins."

"Augustus Ralston," he said, and the name sat between them on the desk. Not Gus. He had never, in Callie's hearing, called him anything but Gus. The use of the full name was the first thing he had given her.

"Augustus Ralston had motive, means, and access to his habits. He was at the auction. He left before the body was found — you have his exit on the same log. And he came to my shop last night and told me, in a voice that did not tremble, that he would hate to see what happened to Wendell happen to someone else." She met his eyes. "I am asking you to look at the man with the motive and the means, Sheriff, instead of the boy with the nervous hands."

The office was very quiet. Outside, the rain came down on the courthouse steps, and somewhere across the square the shop she had locked stood empty with a magnifying glass on the table and nobody in it.

Cross did not speak for a long time. She watched him go through it — she could see the stages of it move across his face the way she saw the stages of a hand move across a page. First the resistance, which was pride, the whole edifice of a case he had spent a week building. Then the crack in the resistance: Ralston's exit at seven-twelve, Eli's sighting in the corridor, and the nine minutes before the alarm. The facts he had not checked because he had not needed to check because the boy had already looked guilty enough. She saw it arrive. She saw him hold it. She did not look away, and neither did he, and the not-looking-away was the closest thing to honesty the room could hold.

He rubbed the back of his neck. Slow, the gesture of a man calculating what it would cost him.

"This isn't how I work, Ms. Thorne." His voice had gone rough. "I work baggies. Chain of custody. I work what I can put in front of a jury. You're giving me paperwork, not evidence."

"I'm giving you the truth." She kept her voice even. "You can verify it. The register, the exit log, the paperback still sitting where Eli left it, the archive access you know was pulled through your own council. You can bring Gus Ralston in and ask him why he signed into the Historical Society eight days before a man was poisoned with the tea that he knew the man drank. You don't have to believe me. You just have to look at it."

Cross looked at it. He looked at the notebook, the register pages, the photograph, the cipher, and the careful transcription of a dead man's prayer. He looked at it for a long time.

Then he picked up the phone.

The sound of it — the lift of the receiver, the press of the first digit — was so quiet she felt it in her teeth. She stood on the other side of the desk and listened to him dial, and she felt the machinery of the town begin to turn, slowly, in the direction it had refused to turn for a hundred and eighty years. And Mae — Mae would hear, and she would understand that the woman she had promised to look after had chosen the truth over the living, and that the choosing was the same as leaving.

Cross spoke into the phone. Low, procedural, the clipped register of a man doing the only thing left to do. He did not thank her. He did not apologize. He gave the order, and the order was the respect, and Callie stood in the sheriff's office with her empty hands and her full notebook, and she waited for the town to learn what she had done to it.

CHAPTER SEVEN: THE RECKONING

The Reckoning

They went for him in the early afternoon, when the rain had thinned to a mist and the light on the hill was the color of old silver. Callie did not go to Ralston Hall. She stayed in the sheriff's office, because Cross had not told her to leave and she had not asked to, and because the thing she had set in motion was still moving and she could not yet look away from it.

She heard it later, in pieces, from a deputy who had been there: how Gus had come to the door himself, in a cashmere sweater, as if he had been expecting the knock for some time. How he had listened to the warrant with his hands loose at his sides and his face composed, and how he had said, *Of course, Sheriff. Let me get my coat,* in the same warm baritone he used at every fundraiser, and how he had walked out under his own power to the car, past the family portrait gallery where the patriarch's eyes had followed every visitor for a hundred and eighty years, and down the drive of the estate that had been built, field by field and fence by fence, on the land a frightened surveyor had measured true and a bought magistrate had measured false. There had been no scene. There had been no resistance. Augustus Ralston did not make scenes. Augustus Ralston made decisions, and the one he made now — to go quietly, to keep the mask — cost him nothing he had not already spent.

They brought him through the front door of the sheriff's office at half past two. Callie was sitting in the chair against the wall, her notebook in her lap, and she looked up when the door opened, and he looked at her.

The look lasted three seconds, maybe four. It was the longest they had ever looked at each other, and the most honest. She had expected hatred, or the flat measuring stare she had seen the night he came to the shop, the ancestor looking out through the descendant's face. What she got was neither. What she got was bewilderment — a genuine, unguarded incomprehension, the face of a man who had spent his whole life certain that peace was worth any price, and who could not, even now, fathom why a quiet woman in a bookshop had decided the truth was worth more. His mouth opened a quarter of an inch, as if he were about to ask her the question — *why* — and then closed again, because there was no answer she could give him that he would understand, and some part of him knew it. He did not look like a man who had been caught. He looked like a man who had been misunderstood, and the tragedy of it was that he believed it, and that, from inside the hundred and eighty years his family had spent building a peace worth protecting, he was not entirely wrong.

Callie held the look. She did not flinch, and she did not look away, and she did not soften, because the bewilderment he was showing her was the most honest thing he had ever given her and she owed it the respect of meeting it. They had guarded the same history, the two of them, for opposite reasons — she to honor the dead, he to bury them — and now, across the sheriff's office, with a deputy at his elbow and the cell door standing open at the end of the hall, they saw each other clearly for the first and last time.

Then he looked away, and he walked to the cell, and the door closed behind him, and the lock caught, and the polished cell that Cross had kept ready for years finally held the man it had been waiting for.

By dusk, the search of Ralston Hall had produced Pike's six missing manuscript pages from a locked desk drawer and a small glass dropper bottle. The state laboratory would later match the residue inside it to the compound in Pike's tea. Gus had carried both evidence and history home with him, trusting the house on the hill to keep what the town had always kept for his family.

The story broke the way stories break in small towns — not in a single flash but in a long, slow tearing, the way a seam gives when you pull the thread Callie had pulled. By evening it was on the square. By the next morning it was in the valley. The Ralston name, which had opened doors and silenced questions for a hundred and eighty years, became in the space of a day the name of the thing it had been built on, and the town that had worn the name like a coat discovered, all at once, what the coat had been lined with.

Callie saw the cost of it in pieces. She saw it in the Historical Society, its doors closed, its sign taken down, the green gingerbread trim looking suddenly shabby under the mist. She saw it in a child on the square — one of Mae's grandchildren, she thought, though she could not be sure at that distance — kicking a ball along the brick walk where the Ralston plaque had been, the plaque gone overnight, the bolt-holes still in the stone like small blank eyes. She saw it in old Mrs. Tucker, who had rented her own family's land from the county for four generations and who stood at her gate the morning the story broke with her hand over her mouth and did not move for twenty minutes. She saw it in the faces of people she had known all her life, who looked at her now the way they might look at the person who had set the fire, even the fire that had needed burning — not with hatred, exactly, but with the particular wariness of people who have learned that the ground they were standing on was not what they thought it was, and who blamed the surveyor.

She kept the shop open. She had nowhere else to be.

Eli Townsend came to her on the second afternoon. Cross had told him, quietly, in the back of the sheriff's office, that he was cleared and would not be charged, and that the state owed him an apology it would not formally make. Eli had stood through it shaking, unable to believe it, because he had spent his whole short life expecting to be blamed for things and had no mechanism for the experience of being believed.

He came into the shop and stood in front of her counter and looked at her. His hands were at his sides, and they were not fidgeting for the first time she had ever seen, and that was how she knew it was real. He tried to speak. He could not. He gave her a nod — small, single — and turned and walked out. Callie stood behind her counter with something pressing against her ribs in a way that had no name.

She saw him once more, a few days later, through the auction-house window as she passed — standing at the long display table where she had found him hunched and hiding, only now he was upright, his shoulders no longer the shoulders of a man trying to be invisible. He was not all right. But he was standing in his own shape for the first time since she had known him, and she counted that as the one thing in the whole wretched business that she did not have to feel the cost of.

Cross came last, at the end of the afternoon, when the shop was empty and the light was going amber. He took off his hat on the threshold, the way he always did, and he stood in the door of her shop with his hands at his sides and the pressed crease in his uniform and the look on his face of a man who had something to say and no practice saying it.

"Ms. Thorne." He stopped. He started again. "I'm not going to stand here and tell you I was wrong. A man in my position doesn't get that luxury." He took a breath. "The case is closed. It's closed right. And I am—" He paused over the word, testing its weight. "—grateful, in a way I'm not accustomed to being."

He held out his hand.

Callie looked at it. It was a large hand, calloused, the hand of a man who ironed his own uniform, and it was extended to her across her own counter on the level of equality, which was a thing he had never offered her and which she had never asked for, and the offering of it was costing him more than the arrest had cost Gus. She reached across the counter and she took it, and they stood there for a moment in the amber light with their hands clasped, and it was small, and it was enormous. She held it for the count of two, and let go.

He let go. He put his hat back on. He left without another word, and the bell rang behind him, and the shop was quiet.

It was full dark when the knock came.

Not the bell. The knock. Two knuckles against the glass of the front door, unhurried, and then silence, and then the knock again. Callie pulled on her coat against the evening chill and came out of the back room, stopping just before the floorboard creaked. Through the glass she could see the shape of Mae Hartwell with a covered dish in her hands and her silver hair done and her good cardigan on, standing on the step in the dark, waiting to be let in instead of walking in, the way she had walked in for thirty years.

Callie opened the door.

They looked at each other. Mae's face was the face Callie had feared most — not angry, not forgiving, just clear, the face of a woman who had spent fifty years holding a door shut and who had just watched the door come off its hinges and was standing now in the draft of it. She did not come in. She held out the dish.

"I brought you soup."

"Thank you."

Mae did not step over the threshold. She stood on the step with the mist in her hair and her hands, when the dish was taken, going to the clasp of her cardigan, and she said, in the unhurried cadence that was hers and no one else's, "There's a Bible on the shelf in my parlor. My grandmother's hand is in it. She wrote what she knew. I could have shown you, Callie. I could have shown anyone. I didn't."

She did not ask for absolution. She said it the way Wren had written his cipher — for the record, because the record deserved it, not because she believed it would set anything right. Her hands, when the dish was gone, had nothing to do, and Callie watched her will them still at her sides, and the stillness of them was the same stillness she had seen in the kitchen the night of the plea, only now it was a chosen stillness, the stillness of a woman who had finally stopped running from the thing she had been carrying. Callie stood in the doorway of her own shop with the warm dish in her hands and received it the way she received every truth she had ever been given: quietly, completely, without flinching, without comfort.

"I know," Callie said. It was the only thing there was to say, and it was true, and it changed nothing, and Mae nodded once, the small nod of a woman who had expected nothing else, and she turned and walked away down the wet street, and the mist closed over her, and she was gone.

Callie closed the door. She set the soup on the counter. She stood in the shop with the lights off and the smell of the evening coming in through the crack of the door, and after a while she became aware of a smell on her own clothes, at the shoulder where Mae had leaned near her in the doorway — sweet, herbal, the smell of sachets and warm kitchens and every soup that had ever been brought to a woman who was not, quite, alone. Lavender. Mae's lavender, on her coat, on her skin, in the weave of her, and she knew, standing there, that she could wash the coat and wash it again and the smell would stay, because some presences do not come out, because they have gone in too deep. The cost of being loved by someone for thirty years is that you carry them whether you are speaking or not.

She did not wash the coat. She took it off and hung it on the hook by the door and left the lavender where it was, and she went into the back room, and the magnifying glass was still on the table where she had set it down, and she did not pick it up. She looked down at her hands in the grey light, and they were stained — the ink stains at the beds of her fingernails, the ones she had scrubbed at for two years and never quite removed, the small daily proof of the work she had inherited and the work she had chosen. She had stopped scrubbing them. She did not remember when. She only knew, standing there, that the stains were no longer something she was trying to get clean of; they were the color her hands had gone, and she would carry them, and the work, and the cost of the work, for whatever came next.

She sat down in the dark and she breathed, and outside the rain came down on the town she had wounded.

CHAPTER EIGHT: AFTER

After

The shop had been open for a week when Callie realized she was no longer waiting for the town to forgive her.

She had not closed it. That had been the first decision, made the morning after, in the grey light before anyone was on the square: she would open the shop, and she would keep opening it, and the opening was the thing she could control when she could control nothing else. She had unlocked the front door and turned the sign and stepped over the floorboard — and then, mid-step, had stepped back onto it, deliberately, so that it creaked, and had stood for a moment in the small unnecessary noise of it. There was no one upstairs to wake. There had not been anyone to wake for two years. She was done being quiet for a ghost.

The first days were the hardest. The shopkeeper across the square would not meet her eye. A woman Callie had known for a decade came in to browse the regional shelf and left without speaking, and the silence was the kind that has a shape, and the shape was blame. Callie rang up the nothing she had bought and watched her go, and she did not call after her, because there was nothing to call, and because the woman was not entirely wrong. Callie had set the fire. The fire had needed burning. The people who lived in the house were allowed to flinch at the smoke.

But a town is a stubborn organism, and it does not stop needing what it needs just because it is angry. By the third day someone came in for a specific edition of a specific book, and Callie found it, and the someone paid and left, and the transaction had been so ordinary it had nearly winded her. On the sixth day the retired men on the bench under the oak nodded to her as she passed — only nodded, nothing more, but a nod from that bench was a verdict, and the verdict was that she was still a person they recognized. On the seventh day, Mrs. Tucker came in. She did not buy anything. She stood for a long time in front of the regional history shelf, and then she turned and looked at Callie across the shop, and her eyes were red but steady, and she said, "Thank you," and Callie nodded, and Mrs. Tucker left, and Callie stood behind her counter and let the small hot thing in her throat be what it was. By the end of the week she had sold eleven books, which was normal, which was what normal had always looked like, and the normalcy of it was the first thing that had not hurt.

Mae had not come back. Callie had washed the dish — the soup dish, the one from Mae's hands on the step — and set it on the shelf by the register where it could be returned, and she had left it there, and she had not taken it over, because the taking-over was Mae's to do or not do. The distance was not a wall. It was a doorway, and Mae would come through it when she came through it. Callie was learning, late, that the woman who knocked was not the woman who had walked away.

The back room was hers now, and she let it be hers.

It still smelled the same — leather and old paper and the faint ghost of bergamot — and she had stopped trying to decide whether the bergamot was the tin or the memory, because the answer was both and the both no longer undid her. Eleanor was in the room the way the grain was in the oak: present, structural, part of the thing, but no longer the only thing. She did her work at the

table where her mother had died, and the table was only a table. She had a great many tables in her life now, and the back room was only the one where she kept her best lamp.

She had moved things. Not much. The scanner to the other wall. The reading lamp to the corner where the morning hit. Small rearrangements that would have been invisible to anyone but her, and that meant, to her, that a woman was living here now instead of performing a vigil.

She made the tea on the morning of the eighth day. She made it the way she had always made it — same tin, same water, same three-minute steep — and she poured it into the chipped mug with the hairline crack, and she carried it to the back room and set it on the oak, and she drank it, and for the first time since the auction it tasted like tea. The bergamot was the bergamot. The grief was still in it, because the grief would always be in it, but she drank it, and it was warm, and the rain was on the windows.

The rain. It had come back in the night, the light patient kind that she had read, all her life, as the sound of safety — the sound of being inside while the world stayed outside. She listened to it now, and the safety was in it again, only it was a different safety, a thinner one, the safety of a woman who knew the outside could come in and who was letting the outside come in and who had decided to be all right anyway. She was no longer hiding in the rain. She was only listening to it. And the listening, she realized, was its own kind of work — the slow work of learning to be in a room without needing the room to save you.

The magnifying glass was on the table where she had left it.

She had not touched it in eight days. She had not needed to. The work she had done in the meantime — the cataloguing, the shelving, the small ordinary business of running a shop — had not required it, and she had let it lie where it lay, the brass catching whatever light came through the window, and she had walked past it the way you walk past a thing whose time has not yet come around again. This morning she looked at it, and the time had come around.

She picked it up.

It was lighter than she remembered. Not in any way she could have proved on a scale — the brass weighed what brass weighed — but lighter in the hand, the way a name is lighter once you have stopped carrying it for someone else. For two years she had held it as a relay runner holds a baton, waiting to hand it back to the woman who had given it to her, except the woman was dead and there was no hand to take it and the running had been the point, the endless running, the carrying that had filled the space where a life was supposed to be. Now she held it as a woman holds a tool she has chosen to use. She turned it in her fingers, the way she had turned it the morning of the auction, letting the morning light run along the beveled edge, and the line came up out of the glass the way it always came, her mother's voice, the words she had been given at nine: *The truth is always there, Callie. Most people just don't look closely enough.* She heard it, and for the first time in two years it was only what it was. It was not a woman handing a child a debt and calling it a gift. It was a true thing her mother had said, once, about looking, and it was still true, and Callie could hold it now without holding the rest.

She set the glass down on the felt rest. Not on the oak. On the rest, where it belonged, where it had always belonged when it was not in use. She had picked it up, and she had set it down, and the setting-down was not a letting-go. It was a putting-away. There was a difference.

She drank her tea. She catalogued a box of estate acquisitions — a set of Methodist sermons, a Civil War nurse's diary, a slim volume of regional poetry with a cracked spine — the sorting, the dating, the penciled notation in a steady hand. She worked through the box by hand and by habit, and it was nearly noon when she pulled the last book from the bottom of the lot and set it on the table and opened it, and stopped.

It was an unremarkable book. A nineteenth-century botanical, hand-colored plates, the kind of thing that came in estate lots by the dozen. She would have shelved it and thought nothing of it. But it was open, and the margins were full.

The hand was not Eleanor's. It was not Jacob Wren's cramped frightened cipher, and it was not Pike's eager downhill slant. It was a hand she had never seen — small, precise, oddly steady, written in a modern blue-black ink by someone who had gone through this book page by page and annotated every plate with names and dates and, in the wider margins, short dense passages in a script that was not quite English and not quite anything else she recognized. The notes were careful. The notes were deliberate. They had been written by someone who very much wanted them to be read, and who had hidden that wanting inside the careful ordinary business of a botanical, the way a voice can hide inside a room. There was no fear in the hand, the way there had been fear in Wren's. There was something else — a patience, almost a playfulness, the marks of a person who had written these notes in the full expectation of being found, and who had enjoyed the hiding of them.

Callie looked at the margin note, and the room narrowed — only a little, only the first fraction of the old narrowing, the world drawing down toward ink and intention — and she felt, under the grief and the cost and the eight grey mornings, a small clean thing she had not felt in a long time. Curiosity. The first thing she had felt, since the auction, that was not a subtraction.

She reached for the glass. The one she had set on the felt rest. The one that was hers now.

She held it over the margin, and she was leaning in, the modern blue-black ink sharpening under the brass, when the knock came.

Not the bell. The knock. Two knuckles against the glass of the front door, unhurried, and then a pause, and then the knock again, patient, the knock of someone who had decided they would wait.

Callie looked up from the margin. She looked at the glass in her hand, and she set it down — gently, on the felt rest, not letting go of it, only setting it down to come back to, because there would be a coming back. She stood, and she stepped on the floorboard so that it creaked, and she walked out of the back room and through the shop to the front door, where the light was bright on the glass and the rain had stopped and someone was waiting on the step to be let in.

She opened the door.

END OF MANUSCRIPT